

INDIA TODAY PHOTO

"WE MODERNISED INTELLIGENCE-GATHERING WITH TECHNOLOGY LIKE DRONES, SATELLITE IMAGING AND AI. THIS ENABLED OUR FORCES TO MAP NAXAL MOVEMENT PATTERNS"

also taken initiatives to reduce foreign aid in LWE areas and frozen the accounts of suspected NGOs and organisations.

Q. Are urban Naxals or Naxal sympathisers or those who support them in various ways in cities also under the scanner?

It is very difficult to identify such people. Identification happens only when devices get into the hands of agencies, as was the case in Maharashtra. More importantly, no one can recruit Naxals from a distance and will have to go the villages to do so. We have ensured they would not be able to go to the villages for recruitment.

Q. You had also called Rahul Gandhi an urban Naxal.

I said the *bhasha* (language) he used was of an urban Naxal.

Q. Much of the spread of Naxals was due to the lack of development in the most backward regions of these states. What has the Modi government done to change that?

That is the fourth prong of our action plan. The moment an area was cleared of Naxalites, we moved in with development

"THE MOMENT AN AREA WAS CLEARED OF NAXALITES, WE MOVED IN WITH DEVELOPMENT SCHEMES. THE IDEA WAS TO ENSURE PEOPLE HAD NO REASON TO GO BACK TO NAXALISM"

schemes. The idea was to ensure that people had no reason to go back to Naxalism. Once they start getting the benefits of these schemes, they turn their back on the Naxals in their villages. Among the things we did was to bring long-needed infrastructure development to these remote areas. In the past 10 years of the Modi government, we have constructed over 11,503 km of roads. Now, we have approved Rs 20,815 crore to construct an additional 17,589 km in the coming years. We have also set about installing mobile towers for cellular communication facilities and, so far, around 2,343 towers have come up at a cost of Rs 4,080 crore in the *pehla charan* (first round). We now plan to build 8,527 more towers that are also 4G compatible via other government schemes. Apart from these, we have opened over 1,007 bank branches and 5,731 post offices in 90 of the most affected districts. Securing saturation in government schemes is not an easy task. Many of the schemes, 112 out of 300, including those for gas connections, toilets, houses and foodgrains, have been altered to suit local demands to ensure their benefits reach the people.

Q. What about initiatives for the youth in the Naxal-affected areas?

The Modi government believes skilling is the best way to break the vicious cycle of poverty. So we laid special emphasis on skilling youth in the Naxal-affected areas to compensate for the losses over the past seven decades. In 48 such districts, Rs 495 crore has been allotted to 48 Industrial Training Institutes (ITIs) and 61 skill development centres have been approved.

Q. How effective have these strategies been?

From August 2019 to December 2020, we completed the preparations, and a comprehensive campaign began soon after. We began clearing out states one after the other. Andhra and Telangana *mein toh kam hi bacha tha* (did not have much of an issue left) when I took charge as home minister, but we completely cleared these states. By 2023, we had cleared Odisha, Bihar, Jharkhand and Madhya Pradesh. We have brought down the total Naxal-affected districts in 10 states from 126 in 2014 to 12 now. There has been an over 70 per cent fall in the death of security personnel and civilians in Naxal-affected areas since 2014. The incidents of violence in these areas have decreased by half. I firmly believe that by March 31, 2026, we will ensure India is totally free of the Naxal threat.